

## Sales Training — Session 32

# The Burnt Buyer.

## Agree First. Extract. Court the Hardest Rejection.

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**WHAT THIS SESSION IS** The most common objection on the phone: "I've heard it all before, I've been burnt, all you guys are the same." The session is a step-by-step playbook for what to say next — and a reframe of the buyer's rejection as a buying signal rather than a brush-off.

### 1. The objection that derails most reps

Every rep on the phones meets the same line at least once a day. "I get these calls every week. I've heard it all before. I've already been burnt by an SEO company and got nothing out of it. All you guys are the same." The line is delivered with conviction, often with a sigh. The rep's instinct — usually — is to defend the agency, argue why we're different, or politely retreat.

All three of those instincts are wrong. The objection isn't a refusal. It's a test. The buyer who actually wants nothing to do with us hangs up. The buyer who delivers the speech is still on the call — which means they're still curious. They want to see what the rep does next. The reps who win this call don't argue, don't retreat, and don't pitch — they agree, then extract.

*"The ones who reject the hardest are the buyers. Most people just move on. The ones who deliver a speech are still on the call — which means they're still interested."*

### 2. Never argue. Agree first. Always.

The single most important rule of the session. When the buyer says "all you guys are the same," the rep's first words are "I totally understand." Not "actually we're different." Not "I hear that, but..." — just "I totally understand." Then a beat. Then a calm, low-key second sentence that acknowledges the buyer's frustration without trying to fix it.

The discipline matters because agreement disarms the buyer's defensive script. They were ready for a fight. The rep refusing to fight breaks the pattern they're expecting. The buyer's brain has to recalibrate — and in that few seconds of recalibration, the conversation tips from adversarial to collaborative.

*"I totally understand where you're coming from — I do this for a living, and we hear the same line from people we ring, too. I'd be saying it myself if I were on your side of the call."*

Resist the temptation to insert a "but." There's no "but" in agree-first. The agreement has to be unqualified. The reps who tack on "...but actually we're different" haven't done agree-first — they've done a polite version of the argument the buyer was already preparing to win. The buyer will hear it and disengage.

### 3. Extract — what would make you feel comfortable?

Immediately after the agreement, the rep flips the question back to the buyer: "What would make you feel comfortable? If we were to start a relationship — what would that need to look like for you?" This is the extraction move. The buyer has been speaking abstractly about their bad experience. The rep is asking them to be specific.

Two things happen at this moment. First, the buyer often doesn't have a ready answer — they're so used to deflecting that nobody has asked them what they actually want. The silence is uncomfortable for them, not for the rep. Second, when they do answer, they have to commit to specifics — "I'd want the campaign to start producing in 90 days," "I'd want to see traffic move 20%," "I'd want monthly check-ins." Those specifics are the rep's negotiation surface. Without them, the rep is shadowboxing. With them, the rep has a brief.

*"How would you see a relationship looking? What would get you across the line? What were the terms with your previous provider — if you don't mind me asking?"*

Notice the last part — "if you don't mind me asking." The rep is requesting information the buyer wouldn't normally share. The polite preface makes it harder to refuse without seeming rude. Most buyers, in the wake of a sincere "I totally understand," will tell the rep more than they intended to.

### 4. "That's interesting" / "That's good feedback" — the receipts

When the buyer answers — with a list of demands, a horror story about their previous provider, a specific concession they want — the rep's next words are not "okay" or "alright" or "yeah." They are: "That's interesting." Or: "That's really good feedback." The words function as receipts — they acknowledge the buyer's input as valuable. People aren't used to being treated as if their words are valuable, and the small dose of recognition opens them up further.

This isn't flattery. The rep means it. The buyer's specific demands are genuinely useful — they tell the rep what the buyer cares about, which is what every successful pitch needs. "That's interesting" is the rep's honest reaction to having just been handed the negotiation brief they couldn't have written themselves.

*"That's interesting. That's really good feedback. Most people don't tell me what they actually want — they just tell me no."*

### 5. "I don't think we can do it, but give me five minutes"

The line that closes the conversation toward the next step. Once the buyer has named their demand — say, three months of pilot work for half price — the rep's response is calibrated low-confidence-high-effort. "I don't think we can do it. But let me check with my manager. Can you give me five minutes? I'll call you back." Three deliberate moves in one sentence.

First, "I don't think we can do it" telegraphs that the rep is on the buyer's side trying to make something happen — not the agency's side trying to extract a sale. Second, "let me check with my manager" creates the negotiation theatre that gives the rep time to think and the buyer time to settle. Third, "can you give me five minutes" — the low time commitment from Session 29 — is almost impossible to refuse.

*"That's really interesting. I don't think we can quite do it, but it's worth a shot, isn't it? Can you give me five minutes? Let me see what I can do for you."*

Note the calibration of the time window. "Five minutes" works. "Ten minutes" puts the buyer on guard — they start wondering whether they're being roped in. Five minutes is the size of a quick coffee — a small, low-cost commitment they can afford to grant. The rep doesn't need five minutes; the rep needs the buyer's permission to come back. The five-minute frame is what unlocks that permission.

## 6. The courting analogy — agree, friendzone, propose coffee

The session's most useful (and most uncomfortable) mental model. The dynamic of winning over a burnt buyer is structurally identical to courting someone who has decided in advance they don't want to be courted. They've put up a wall. The rep's instinct is to break the wall down. That fails. The successful move is to agree with the wall, ask what would make them lower it themselves, and propose a small low-stakes meeting that they can accept without commitment.

Translate the dynamic into the sales context:

- "All you guys are the same" ≈ "all men just want one thing." The opener is a defensive statement of disappointment, not a refusal to talk.
- Agree, don't argue. "You're probably right." The argument the buyer was preparing for never happens, and they have to recalibrate.
- Friendzone yourself. "Whether we end up working together or not, I'd love to understand what would actually help you." No pressure to commit.
- Propose coffee, not lunch. A 10-minute Zoom, not a 45-minute meeting. A screenshot, not a proposal. Match the size of the ask to where the buyer is — which is barely-interested.
- Listen for the real story. The buyer will, eventually, tell you what actually went wrong with their previous provider. That's the brief. Use it.

*"Court them. They've had their heart broken by an SEO company. The last thing you want to do is open with 'we're way better.' Open with 'I understand,' then ask what would make them feel comfortable."*

## 7. "What do I need to become?" — the flip

Inside the extraction move sits a specific verbal flip worth memorising. Rather than asking "what can we do for you?" — which positions the rep as a vendor at a desk — the rep can

ask "what do I need to become?" The phrasing is slightly off-balance, slightly intimate, and it tells the buyer that the rep is willing to be reshaped by the buyer's input.

Buyers respond to this in surprising ways. The slight strangeness of the phrasing forces them out of autopilot. They have to actually think — not retrieve a canned response. And what they say next is usually more honest than what they would have said to "what can we do?"

*"What do I need to do, and what do I need to become — for you to even consider giving us a shot?"*

## 8. The buyer's wishlist isn't a wishlist — it's a test

Critical interpretive frame. When the buyer responds to the extraction question with a list of demands — "I want a free month, no contract, double the traffic in 60 days, refund if it doesn't work" — the rep should NOT interpret that list as the actual price of doing business. Almost no buyer expects every item on the list to be granted. The list is a test. They want to see how the rep handles being asked for the impossible.

The right move is the callback frame from Section 5. "I don't think we can do that, but let me see what I can do." Then come back with something — not everything they asked for, but something. The buyer's reaction to the counter-offer is the real negotiation. Most of the time they'll accept a fraction of their original list — because they didn't really want the list, they wanted to see whether the rep took them seriously.

*"They always ask high. They know it's unrealistic. If you actually agreed to everything, they'd panic and back out, because it would feel too easy and that means something's wrong. Don't give them everything."*

This is also why the close usually happens at the meeting, not on the call. The buyer's demand list extracts the meeting — the meeting is where the value gets built and the real terms get negotiated. The rep who tries to close everything on the call usually loses the deal entirely.

## 9. Patterns become products — the whiteboard rule

A scaling move for the team rather than the individual rep. Every time a rep gets a specific demand from a buyer ("I want a month free," "I want a 30-day exit clause," "I want a fixed-fee guarantee"), that demand goes on the whiteboard. Patterns emerge fast. If twelve buyers in a row ask for the same thing, the agency should consider whether that thing should become a standard product option — and the rep on the next call should be able to offer it without needing to "check with the manager."

This is the difference between salespeople and theoretical marketers. A theoretical marketer designs products in a vacuum and tries to sell them. A salesperson listens to the demand pattern, names it, and engineers a product that fits it. The team's job is the listening half. The

agency's job is to turn the patterns into products that close more easily next month than they did this month.

*"If you keep banging your head against the same wall, let me build you the tool to get unstuck. I'm a salesperson first, marketer second. I'll reverse-engineer products around the demand."*

## 10. Buyers are replaceable — the abundance frame

A reset move for the rep's mental state. The buyer on the other end isn't unique. The next buyer is one phone call away. Every buyer is replaceable. This sounds harsh but it's the mental discipline that protects the rep from the desperate, clingy energy that buyers can detect within seconds and use against them.

A rep who NEEDS this deal hands the buyer leverage they didn't earn. The buyer can feel the neediness in the rep's tone and exploit it — drag out the call, ask for more concessions, ghost on the follow-up. A rep who knows the next deal is a phone call away is calmer, more patient, and willing to walk. Buyers want to deal with the second kind of rep, because the second kind seems credible. The first kind seems hungry, and hungry is unattractive.

*"Customers are replaceable. The last one was difficult? Next call. Jackpot. That's the energy. Endless pipeline, endless opportunity. If you let one bad call colour the next ten, the next ten get worse, because you've decided they will."*

The discipline isn't to stop caring about the deal. The discipline is to stop NEEDING any one specific deal. The two are different. A rep can want a deal badly and still walk away from a bad set of terms, because the next deal is right there. That posture is what closes more deals than any tactic in this playbook.

## 11. Listening is the master skill

The session ended on a quieter point. Every technique in this playbook collapses if the rep isn't actually listening. The agree-first move works because the rep heard what the buyer said. The extraction works because the rep is paying attention to the specifics. The callback works because the rep remembers what the buyer asked for. None of it works on autopilot.

The reps who fall behind on these calls are the ones thinking about what they'll say next while the buyer is still talking. The reps who close are the ones who shut up, listen for the actual content of the objection, and respond to THAT — not to a generic version of it they prepared on the way to the desk. The buyer can tell the difference instantly.

*"Use your ears. It's the same thing every day. The reps who fall behind are the ones planning what to say next while the buyer is still talking."*

## 12. Action items for the team

1. Memorise the opener: "I totally understand. We hear it from people we ring too. What would actually make you feel comfortable?" Practise it aloud until it stops feeling rehearsed.
2. Eliminate "but" from your agreement sentences. "I understand, but..." is not agreement. "I understand. [Pause.] Tell me what would change that for you" is.
3. Add "That's interesting" and "That's really good feedback" to your verbal toolkit. Use them as receipts after the buyer gives you any specific information.
4. Practise the callback line verbatim: "I don't think we can do it, but it's worth a shot — can you give me five minutes?" Five minutes, not ten.
5. Start a team whiteboard for buyer demands. Every time a buyer asks for something specific, log it. Look for patterns weekly. Patterns become product options.
6. Practise the "what do I need to become" flip on at least three calls this week. Note who answers honestly and who deflects — the honest answers are the strongest leads.
7. After every call, ask yourself: was I listening or planning my next line? If you can't recount the buyer's specific complaint, you weren't listening. Recalibrate on the next call.

**THE RULE OF THUMB** The buyer who delivers the "all you guys are the same" speech is still on the call — and that makes them a buyer. Agree first. Extract what they want. Promise five minutes. Don't argue. The hardest rejections come from the buyers most ready to be won.